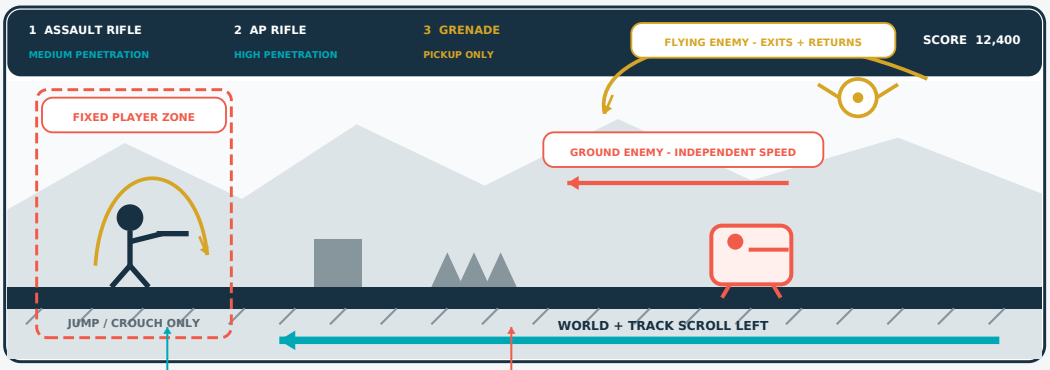
1 TITLE + PITCH

THE FRONT NEVER STOPS

A one-hit-death 2D auto-scrolling run-and-gun in which a horizontally anchored player reads incoming patterns, switches weapons to break armor, and chooses between safe survival and a higher kill score.

Reinvents: Contra | William Zhu | Version 3.0 | September 20, 2026

2 GAME SPACE + MOMENT-TO-MOMENT LOOP



3 CALLOUTS

CONTROLS
jump/crouch • mouse/right-stick aim • fire/swap/reload/guard

PRESSURE
track hazards • bullets • enemy speeds • reload timing

MAIN VERBS
read • jump • crouch • guard • aim • shoot • swap

1. **GAME** — SEND PATTERN — hazards + enemy paths
2. **PLAYER** — READ + DEFEND — jump / crouch / guard
3. **PLAYER** — AIM + ATTACK — swap / break / weak point
4. **GAME** — RESOLVE + ADVANCE — score / checkpoint / harder pattern

4 DESCRIPTION - THE BROKEN ASSUMPTION

Contra normally asks the player to move horizontally through the stage. This design removes horizontal movement and brings the stage and independently moving enemies toward the player instead. The game still works because one-hit death, multidirectional shooting, pattern learning, weapon choice, and stage progression are preserved.

5 ARMOR PENETRATION + BOSS FIGHT

DETAIL ILLUSTRATION - ARMOR

AR: medium penetration / balanced fire. AP Rifle: high penetration / slow fire.



UNARMORED

Any bullet or stomp kills in one hit.

LIGHT ARMOR

One shot breaks armor and the next kills. A stomp kills immediately.

HEAVY ARMOR

Assault Rifle shots ricochet; the AP Rifle breaks armor and the next hit kills. A stomp only slides the enemy.

WEAK POINT

One precise hit bypasses either armor level and kills immediately.

BOSS FIGHT

The Boss fight stays on a straight horizontal 2D track. 'Looping' means hand-authored track modules return over time; the track never bends or forms a circle on screen. Player and Boss remain relatively stable while hazards and usable objects move right to left. Projectile density and track hazards are reduced for readability. Death restarts the full Boss encounter.

HOW TO DAMAGE THE BOSS

- Shoot the Boss directly.
- Trigger passing track objects to attack it.
- Break armor first, then hit the exposed weak point.

WIN Clear 6-8 segments and defeat the Boss.

LOSE Take one unguarded hit or hit an unblockable hazard.

SCORE More enemy kills produce a higher final score.

6 SIDEBAR

TARGET PLAYER

Precision aiming, pattern learning, and short high-stakes runs.

PLATFORM

PC; keyboard and mouse or controller.

SESSION

6-8 minutes; 6-8 segments of 30-45 seconds.

SMALL-TEAM SCOPE

1 stage, 4 enemy types, 3 weapons, 2 permanent slots, 1 Boss.

ART

Original military sci-fi pixel art with modern lighting and clear silhouettes.

AUDIO

Chiptune plus electronic drums; distinct ricochet, armor-break, reload, guard-break, and death cues.



AI-GENERATED BOSS MOOD REF
OpenAI ImageGen - 20 Sep 2026



AI-GENERATED STAGE MOOD REF
OpenAI ImageGen - 20 Sep 2026

AI DISCLOSURE ChatGPT assisted with layout and wording; ImageGen created the two labeled mood references. The game-space graphic is a functional diagram, not generated art. Gameplay decisions were supplied and revised by William Zhu. No original Contra assets are reused.